

The Vancouver Restaurant Squeeze: A 10-Point Narrative of the Decade That Changed Dining

Part 1: The Sticker Shock: A Decade of Price Inflation in Vancouver's Restaurants

The primary symptom of the restaurant squeeze, and the one most acutely felt by consumers, is the dramatic inflation of menu prices between 2015 and 2025. This increase has far outpaced the official Consumer Price Index (CPI), transforming everyday casual meals into near-luxuries. While the Business Council of B.C. notes that "food purchased from restaurants" rose 24% between January 2019 and July 2024 ¹, this figure belies the much harsher reality for specific, popular items.

This discrepancy is most evident in iconic, casual Vancouver staples. A decade ago, archival blog posts from 2014 and 2015 show a large, steaming bowl of pho was a dependable, affordable meal, priced between \$8.40 and \$8.50.² By 2025, that price has effectively doubled. Consumers now lament that a \$10 bowl is a "time travel" fantasy ³, with typical prices for a bowl of pho now landing in the \$15 to \$16 range, or more.⁴

This trend holds for other daily purchases. In 2016, Vancouver's average price for a coffee (like a latte) was \$3.66.⁵ By 2025, that average is cited as \$5.00.⁶ Even the fast-food "deal" has evaporated, with a typical combo meal now costing between \$15 and \$20.⁶ On the higher end, in 2015, a three-course menu at a top-tier restaurant during the Dine Out Vancouver festival cost \$38.⁷ By 2025, a *moderate* per-person dinner, not a special event, is defined as costing between \$50 and \$75.⁸

Item	Approx. 2015 Price	Approx. 2025 Price	Approx. % Increase
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Large Bowl of Pho	\$8.50 ²	\$16.00 ⁴	88%
Latte/Coffee	\$3.66 (in 2016) ⁵	\$5.00 ⁶	37%
Fast-Food Combo	(not specified)	\$15.00 - \$20.00 ⁶	N/A
Dine Out Van Meal (Top Tier)	\$38.00 ⁷	\$65.00+ (Current Tiers)	71%+
Moderate Dinner (Per Person)	(not specified)	\$50.00 - \$75.00 ⁸	N/A

Part 2: The Consumer Retreat: "I Just Can't Afford to Go Out Anymore"

This "sticker shock" is not just anecdotal; it is the primary driver of a quantifiable consumer retreat. According to a September 2025 report from Restaurants Canada, three in four Canadians (75%) are actively eating out less, citing the high cost of living as the main reason.⁹

This pullback is most severe among the restaurant industry's most critical demographic: young diners. The share of people cutting back on dining out rises to a staggering 81% for those aged 18 to 34.⁹ This is a demographic in conflict; while Millennials (51%) and Gen Z (47%) are still the most likely to make a purchase from a restaurant at least once a week ¹⁰, they are the ones most acutely feeling the financial pressure.

This pressure has triggered a "trade-down" effect, which is the single most important behavioural shift in the 2025 market. Consumers are not stopping eating prepared food, but they are en masse shifting their spending away from full-service restaurants and toward quick-service restaurants (QSRs).

The data is stark. In 2019, per capita spending at full-service restaurants was \$1,165. By 2025, it has plummeted to \$1,035. In sharp contrast, spending at quick-service establishments has remained stable, shifting from \$1,150 in 2019 to \$1,135 in 2025.¹⁰ Consumers are also shifting the *time* of day they eat out, "opting for breakfast menus over dinner because it's less expensive".⁹ This is confirmed by QSR lunch traffic, which, driven by affordability concerns and return-to-office mandates, has surpassed pre-pandemic levels, rising 7.6%.¹⁰ Furthermore, 65% of Canadians now report replacing a traditional meal with a snack at least once a

month.¹⁰

Part 3: The Operator's Squeeze: Why 41% of Restaurants Are Losing Money

While consumers grapple with high prices, restaurant operators are facing an even more severe crisis of profitability. The consumer perception of "greedy" restaurants is fundamentally disconnected from the financial reality. As of June 2025, 41% of B.C. restaurants were operating at a loss or merely breaking even.⁹

The restaurant industry operates on notoriously thin net profit margins, typically in the 3% to 5% range.¹⁴ This leaves no buffer for the "double-digit" growth in core operational costs—specifically food, labour, and insurance—that operators have experienced.⁹

This has created a "doom loop":

1. Rising operational costs (labour, food, rent) erase the 3-5% profit margin.
2. To survive, operators are "pressured to raise prices, reduce staff, change menus and adjust their store hours".⁹
3. As Part 2 demonstrated, these higher prices are the primary reason customers are staying away, leading to a consumer retreat.¹⁰
4. This loss of customers forces the restaurant to raise prices further on their remaining clientele, accelerating the cycle.

The most revealing evidence of this squeeze comes from the BC Restaurant and Foodservices Association (BCRFA), which states that current menu prices are already *artificially suppressed*. If restaurants were to actually pass on all their cost increases and maintain a healthy margin, "a hamburger would be about \$30 on a menu".¹³ The fact that 41% of operators are unprofitable⁹ is the mathematical proof of this claim. Consumers are experiencing sticker shock on prices that are already subsidized by the restaurant owners themselves, who are absorbing the loss until they can no longer afford to and are forced to close.

The table below illustrates how a healthy restaurant P&L in 2015 has become an unsustainable one by 2025.

Cost Category	% of Revenue (c.	% of Revenue (c.	Justification
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	2015)	2025)	
Cost of Goods Sold (COGS)	30%	38%	Food costs have grown by double digits. ⁹
Labour Costs	30%	38%	Minimum wage up 70% ¹⁵ , new taxes ¹⁶ , labour shortages. ¹³
Rent/Occupancy	12%	18%	Skyrocketing commercial leases and property taxes. ¹⁶
Other (Insurance, Fees, etc.)	5%	10%	Insurance rates have doubled or tripled ¹⁸ , new fees. ¹⁹
Total Costs	77%	104%	
Net Profit / Loss	+23% (Gross) / ~8% (Net)	-4% (Net Loss)	41% of restaurants are at a loss or breaking even. ⁹

Part 4: The Labour Crisis: A 70% Wage Hike and a 16,000-Chef Shortage

The single largest driver of the cost squeeze is payroll.¹⁶ This is not due to one factor, but a "triple whammy" of wage hikes, acute labour shortages, and new government-mandated payroll costs.

First, the base cost of labour has exploded. In 2015, B.C.'s general minimum wage was \$10.45 per hour. As of June 1, 2025, it is \$17.85 per hour.¹⁵ This represents a 70.8% increase in the wage floor in one decade. Compounding this, the B.C. government eliminated the lower "liquor server" minimum wage on June 1, 2021.²⁰ This forced a sudden and significant wage

hike for all front-of-house staff, a cost that was immediately transferred to menu prices.

Second, this wage floor is largely irrelevant in a market defined by a critical labour *shortage*. The BCRFA estimates the province is "short upwards of 16,000 cooks and chefs" ¹³, with other estimates as high as 15,000-20,000.²² This massive skills gap, with only 800 people graduating from culinary school to fill 16,000 vacancies ¹³, forces restaurants to pay well above the new, higher minimum wage simply to attract and retain kitchen staff.¹⁶

Third, on top of these high, market-driven wages, operators have been burdened with new, non-negotiable statutory costs. These include the Employer Health Tax (EHT), introduced in 2019, which taxes payroll directly ¹⁶, and the introduction of provincially mandated paid sick days in 2022.¹⁶ This combination of a 70% higher wage floor, a 16,000-person skills gap, and new payroll taxes has made labour an unsustainable expense for many.

Part 5: The Unaffordable City: When Rent and Taxes Kill a Legacy

In a city as expensive as Vancouver, the second-biggest killer after payroll is real estate. Skyrocketing commercial rents and unpredictable, escalating property taxes have become an existential threat, forcing out even popular, profitable, and long-running "legacy" businesses.

The 2023 closure of Kent's Kitchen in Chinatown is a perfect micro-narrative of this trend. The beloved institution, which provided "affordable, culturally appropriate food," was not closed for a lack of customers but due to "skyrocketing rent." A community leader at the time explicitly blamed the "trickle-down effect from increased property taxes," linking the real estate crisis directly to food insecurity.¹⁷

This story is repeated across the city. Zefferelli's Spaghetti Joint, an institution on Robson Street for 36 years, closed its doors in May 2025.²⁵ Public reaction immediately and correctly identified "Greedy landlords" and "higher property taxes" as the culprits.²⁷ Similarly, Pizzeria Farina, a 13-year-old Main Street staple ²⁸, was "forced to close" on May 31, 2025, after the "building in which it resides [was] sold".²⁶

The cases of Pizzeria Farina ²⁹ and La Taqueria's original location ²⁶ reveal that the threat is not just high rent, but *precarity*. Successful businesses are being evicted because their buildings are sold for redevelopment. This market dynamic makes it nearly impossible to build a 20- or 30-year legacy business. Instead, it filters out these community hubs and favors either large-capital chains or high-margin "destination" restaurants ³¹ that can generate a

high return on a short 5-year lease before the building is demolished.

Part 6: The Global Supply Chain Hits Home: Floods, Strikes, and the Price of Food

The Cost of Goods Sold (COGS) for restaurants has been under assault from both global inflation and a series of uniquely B.C.-specific catastrophes. Between 2019 and 2024, B.C. restaurants have been clobbered by price hikes on core ingredients: meat (up 36%), dairy products and eggs (up 30%), and vegetables and vegetable preparations (up 30%).¹

These baseline increases have been exacerbated by severe supply chain shocks. The November 2021 floods "wreaked havoc on a number of major transportation routes"³², cutting restaurants off "from the supply chains they rely on".³⁴ The event was so disruptive that it had global consequences: McDonald's in *Japan* was forced to limit sales of medium and large-sized fries *because* the floods had cut off the supply of potatoes from the Vancouver Port.³²

More recently, labour actions and strikes at B.C.'s ports, including Vancouver and Prince Rupert, have created further volatility. These ports handle 20% of U.S. trade and are a critical entry point for food.³⁵ A port shutdown stalls "nearly \$800 million in daily trade"³⁵, putting "perishable goods at risk of spoilage" and adding "increased transportation costs" that are passed directly to operators and, ultimately, consumers.³⁵ These shocks create not just higher prices but *menu instability*, forcing restaurants to "reduce their menu items or close for certain hours"³⁴, adding another hidden layer of cost and chaos.

Part 7: Death by a Thousand Cuts: Insurance, Taxes, and Red Tape

Beyond the "big three" costs of labour, rent, and food, Vancouver's restaurant operators are being bled dry by a swarm of escalating, non-negotiable administrative costs.

Commercial insurance has become a significant, unforeseen burden. Brokers serving the restaurant industry report that in the last few years, many clients are "paying two to three times what they used to" for property and casualty coverage.¹⁸ Other reports cite premium

hikes of "a minimum of 20% and to a maximum of 60%".³⁶ These increases are often unrelated to the restaurant's own claims history, instead reflecting global climate-related risks.³⁶

At the provincial level, operators face "red tape" costs that add no value. A prime example is the \$2.1 billion surplus held by WorkSafeBC.³⁷ Restaurants Canada is actively lobbying the B.C. government to "Return all or part" of this surplus to employers, arguing that businesses are being squeezed for premiums while their mandatory insurer sits on a massive, unspent reserve.³⁷

At the municipal level, fees are also rising. The City of Vancouver's business license "Per Employee" fee, for example, has been scheduled to increase from \$105 in 2023 to \$145 in 2025.¹⁹ This represents a 38% increase in this specific fee in just two years. These costs are uniquely painful because they are inelastic; they cannot be negotiated, and they extract revenue from an industry that is already 41% unprofitable.⁹

Part 8: The Double-Edged Sword of Delivery Apps

Third-party delivery applications (like DoorDash, Uber Eats, and SkipTheDishes) provided a critical lifeline during the pandemic but have become a devastating, double-edged sword for profitability. These apps typically charge restaurants commission fees as high as 20-30%.³⁸

For a restaurant operating on a 3-5% net margin¹⁴, a 30% commission means they lose money on every order. The only possible response for the restaurant is to inflate their menu prices *on the app*. Consumers are not wrong when they notice items are "often \$2-3 more through the apps"⁴¹; one analysis notes that a 30% commission requires a price markup of approximately 43% for the restaurant to maintain its original margin.⁴²

The B.C. government has attempted to regulate this predatory environment, first by implementing a permanent 20% cap on the fees apps can charge restaurants⁴³, and second by mandating a new minimum wage for gig workers (\$20.88 per hour).²²

However, the apps' response was simply to pass these new costs directly to the consumer. For example, in response to the new B.C. gig worker wage law, DoorDash added a "Regulatory Response Fee".⁴⁶ This has resulted in a "fee stack" that destroys consumer trust and value. A customer ordering from an app now faces:

1. The restaurant's base menu price (already high).
2. A further, app-specific markup on that item.⁴¹
3. A "Delivery Fee."

4. A "Service Fee."
5. A B.C.-specific "Regulatory Response Fee".⁴⁶
6. A prompt for a tip.

This opaque and infuriating stack makes the final price feel like a scam, accelerating the consumer retreat⁴⁷ and further damaging the restaurant's reputation, even though the restaurant is also a victim of the app's fee structure.

Part 9: The Hollowing Out of the Middle: A City of Michelin Stars and Food Courts

The cumulative effect of these pressures is not a uniform squeeze; it is a *polarization* of Vancouver's dining scene. The market is being "hollowed out," creating a city of high-end "destination" dining and low-end fast food, while the "middle"—the affordable, full-service, neighbourhood restaurant—is being systematically eliminated.

The Top End Thrives: Vancouver's high-end scene is booming. It is being celebrated with new Michelin Guide entries³¹ and culinary awards.⁴⁸ These are high-margin businesses with a clientele that is not price-sensitive. They can absorb the high labour and rent costs by building them into a premium, "experience-based" price.

The Low End Thrives: The Quick-Service Restaurant (QSR) sector is also thriving. As demonstrated in Part 2, consumers are "trading down" for value.⁹ QSR per capita spending is stable¹⁰, and lunch traffic is up 7.6% as diners seek affordable, functional meals.¹⁰

The Middle Dies: The real story of the squeeze is the death of the mid-market. This is where the closures of beloved "legacy businesses"¹⁷ are concentrated. This list includes:

- Zefferelli's Spaghetti Joint (36 years)²⁵
- Ma Dang Goul (30 years)²⁵
- Solly's Bagels (30-year-old W. Broadway location)²⁵
- Penang Bistro (21 years)²⁵
- McKim Wonton Mein Saga (15 years)²⁵
- Pizzeria Barbarella (13 years)⁴⁹
- Pizzeria Farina (13 years)²⁵
- Kent's Kitchen (long-time affordable staple)¹⁷
- Potluck Hawker Eatery⁵⁰

This "hollowing out" is not just an economic story; it is a cultural one. A Michelin restaurant is a

"special occasion" destination. A food court is a place of function. The mid-market restaurant is the *social* place—the "third place" outside of home and work where community is built. The squeeze is eliminating the city's social fabric, leaving a polarized landscape of high-cost luxury and low-cost function, with little in between.

Part 10: The Social Contract Breaks: Tipping Fatigue and the Final Straw

The final, psychological factor driving consumers away is the collapse of the social contract around tipping. As menu prices have soared to cover the costs detailed in Parts 4-8, "tipping fatigue" has set in, making the final, tip-inflated bill feel punitive and breaking the value proposition of eating out.

The consumer backlash is visceral. Diners report "unprecedented fatigue"⁵¹ and feel that the "sense of entitlement to higher tips is growing" while, simultaneously, "prices are up, portions are down, quality is down, service is worse".⁴⁷ The core of the issue is that the final, tip-inflated price is simply "not worth it" anymore.⁴⁷

This fatigue is a direct, logical consequence of the labour market changes in Part 4. When B.C. eliminated the lower server wage in 2021²⁰, it transferred that cost from the consumer's tip to the restaurant's payroll. The restaurant, having no margins¹⁴, immediately passed this new cost to the consumer via higher menu prices.

The result is that consumers are (rightly) confused and resentful. They are being asked to pay a menu price that is 30-50% higher than a few years ago *and* are still being prompted by a payment machine to add a 20-30% tip, all while knowing that the server's base wage is 70.8% higher than it was in 2015.¹⁵

This has broken the perceived fairness of the transaction. Tipping fatigue is, in effect, the consumer's *veto* on the industry's broken economics. The restaurant, unable to survive on its menu prices, is using "tip-flation" to cover its exploding costs. The consumer, who is *also* being squeezed⁹, is using the tip screen as their one and only point of power. By staying home⁵² or pushing back, the consumer is actively rejecting the industry's desperate attempt to pass on its unmanageable costs. This social breakdown is the final straw accelerating the consumer retreat and sealing the fate of the mid-market restaurant. It has even created a new market for restaurants, like Vancouver's Folke, that are built on a "no-tipping," all-in-price model, an explicit solution to this broken social contract.⁵³

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